



The actual and ideal self

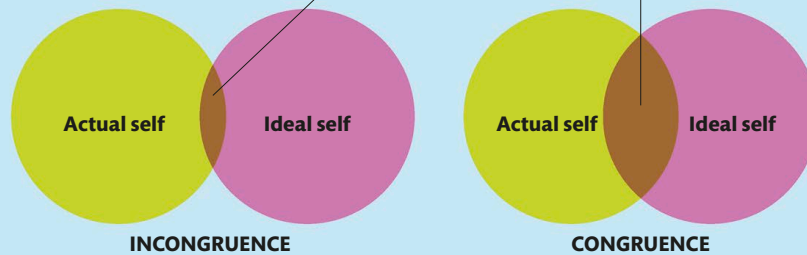
There can sometimes be a difference between who we believe we are (our actual self) and who we aspire to be (our ideal self). How we perceive our actual self shifts in response to feedback and challenges from the social environment. Some psychologists believe that when our actual self is close to our ideal self, we are more able to live a balanced, happy life.

Congruence

When the difference between our actual self and ideal self is small, we are said to be "congruent."

Small overlap indicates our actual self does not reflect who we aspire to be

Large overlap suggests our actual self is similar to who we aspire to be



SELF AND IDENTITY

The self is a first-person account of how we perceive and evaluate ourself. Identity involves the specific beliefs and characteristics that can be used to define a person and distinguish them from others.



The development of self

The concept of self begins as soon as we are able to recognize that we are an individual being that is distinct from other objects and people. This basic sense of self happens shortly after birth, but it is not until our second year of life that we begin to develop a more complicated view of who we are.



2 YEARS OLD

Self-description

By two years old, toddlers begin to refer to themselves as "me." They often describe themselves as they may be perceived by other people.



3-4 YEARS OLD

Categorical sense of self

Young children define themselves in terms of properties and categories—these are usually concrete, such as age or hair color.



6 YEARS OLD

Defining self against peers

By school age, children start comparing themselves to their peers. Many beliefs about their self stem from how others react to them.

DO DOGS RECOGNIZE THEMSELVES IN A MIRROR?

Dogs fail the mirror test, but some scientists have argued that the test might not work for animals that do not rely on sight as their primary sense.

60 PERCENT OF
SOCIAL MEDIA
USERS SAY IT
NEGATIVELY
IMPACTS
HOW THEY
FEEL ABOUT
THEMSELVES

